A Bell for Shorty

By Jim May

(Pg 189) My father's nickname was Shorty. He wasn't particularly short, but he was the second son born to a farm family of twelve children, and when his oldest brother, my uncle Ben, gave him the nickname, it stuck. As I grew up, it never occurred to me that his nickname had anything to do with his height. It was simply what most people called my father. Our family called him Dad.

My father was fifty-one years old when I was born.

INTRODUCTION

Jim May was born in Spring Grove, Illinois. Raised in this small German-Catholic farming community, his stories resonate with the rural voices of the Illinois prairie. His relatives spent time "visiting" and telling stories as an integral part of daily life–a means of weaving the social fabric of the community.

As an Emmy award-winning storyteller and author, he seeks to reestablish storytelling as an art form, ideal not only for entertainment and education, but also for the grounding and healing that is needed in complex, modern times.

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This story pays tribute to the most influential man in his life – his father "Shorty." A Bell for Shorty by Jim May

The best thing about being the youngest was the year I had my father all to myself. I was five years old, and there was no kindergarten at the one-room school I would attend the following fall. My oldest sister was married and my other two sisters were in high school. My brother was working construction, and my mother assembled typewriters at a factory in Woodstock. Each day, after an enormous farm breakfast of bacon, sausage, fried potatoes, eggs, pancakes, and German coffeecake, everyone scattered to their destinations in town, leaving Dad and me, the oldest and the youngest, at home to be the real farmers.

I went along to work in the fields, too. I remember sitting with Dad high up on the iron seat of the old tractor, the big seat with the holes drilled in it for the rainwater to drain through. There was plenty of room for both of us on that wide, flat, piece of iron. I sat half in his lap, surrounded by his arms as he held the steering

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wheel. Sometimes I'd grab the wheel and "help" him steer.

In those days, even though I was five years old, I never thought of myself as being "babysat." I was the official "hooker-upper" on the place, and could drive a tractor, in a manner of speaking. In late summer the corn stood tall in the fields but was still green and juicy. We'd hook up a hay wagon to the tractor. I'd lift the wagon tongue (most were four-wheeled in those days, so there was no weight on the tongue) while Dad backed the tractor toward me. When the coupling hole in the tractor's drawbar matched the hole in the wagon tongue, I'd drop a pin through both holes, joining the wagon and tractor. I was proud of this contribution because I knew that it would have been nearly impossible for my dad to do that job alone. Next we'd pull the wagon down to the cornfield, cut and load some corn, and feed it to the cows when they came up to the barn for milking.

My job was to "drive" the tractor while Dad cut the corn. Once we reached the cornfield, he'd put the

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tractor in first gear and hold the clutch pedal to the floor. Then I'd put my small work shoe on top of his heavy work boot, and while the tractor continued to run he would slowly slide his foot out from under mine. I could feel the tension of the clutch pedal rising against my foot and as I pushed back with all my weight, the pedal would slowly depress again. At that moment I took control of the big machine.

I was pleased that I had saved him a lot of time and effort walking back and forth to the wagon and climbing on and off the tractor to move it closer to his work. He was nearly sixty years old and farming three hundred acres by himself; even then I was aware of his age and how hard he worked.

There were times when I couldn't go along with him, times when I had to stay alone back at the house. There was the time that I rang the bell.

I watched Dad milk and feed the cows, helped him hook up the corn planter, and looked on as he filled first the

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canisters that held the fertilizer and then the ones that contained the corn seed itself. When he was finished and had tightened the last wing nut on the last bolt, he looked at me, thought for a moment, and said as he turned toward the tractor, "You'll have to stay home today."

I didn't understand why. It seemed like a horrible injustice. Looking back, I think he may have been afraid to have me sitting with him on the tractor seat that day. There was a lot of moving around when you planted corn. We used an ancient two-row planter that had been converted from horse-drawn to mechanical. A man sitting on the tractor had to reach around and back to put the planter in gear by hand. The marker arms had to be lifted and dropped again at the end of every pass so that each row of corn was properly spaced for future cultivating and harvesting. With all that movement, a small boy could easily be bumped and fall under the tractor wheel. Farming is dangerous work. Every farmer knew a friend or relative who had lost a hand or an arm

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to a machine. Local accounts of some child crushed under the wheel of a tractor or truck served as moral lessons and cautionary tales.

Before he got on the tractor. Dad turned to me and said, "I know you'll be alone, so if there's trouble, ring the bell."

A rusty, cinnamon-colored bell hung from a wooden frame on the roof of a storage shed we called the shanty. The shanty was attached to the house. I had never heard the bell.

"It's not for fun or foolishness, but if there's trouble, ring the bell. I'll hear it in the field and come back in on the tractor."

He left for the field. I watched the tractor roll down the lane, getting smaller and smaller. Finally it was out of sight. I didn't like being there alone. I was afraid someone might come down the driveway. It wasn't just strangers that scared me. I was just plain shy, frightened even of neighbors.

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The time was passing ever so slowly, so I thought I'd go into the shanty to play.

When my eyes had adjusted to the darkness, I saw our dog, Bootsie, asleep in a dirt hole. Curled up next to her was a snake. This snake looked threatening, and I had overheard some talk about rattlesnakes on neighbors' farms. Recalling my father's words, I thought to myself. This could be trouble. I looked up at the bell. I liked the idea of ringing it. I liked the idea of Dad coming in early from the field. I knew he'd be coming in for the noon meal, which we called dinner, but it was still mid-morning and I didn't want to wait. I looked at the snake again and it seemed to have gotten bigger, with a more sinister look on its face. I thought. This is trouble enough.

I grabbed the old hemp rope and gave it a pull that literally lifted my feet off the ground. When the side of the rusty bell hit the clapper, it sent a low, rich toll out over the fields. I liked the sound so much that I gave it another pull.

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When the toll had drifted away, I heard something else: the engine of my father's tractor. He had heard the bell and was coming in from the field.

When I saw his tractor belching smoke and coming into the yard at full speed, I knew that he was worried about me and I thought, Maybe I am in trouble!

The tractor braked, coming to a stop right in front of me. He turned the engine off and it got real quiet, the kind of stillness only noticed after it has been preceded by a loud noise. "What's the trouble?" he asked, still seated on the tractor.

"There's a snake over there by Bootsie!" I replied, pointing to the shanty. He climbed down off the tractor and walked quickly to the old building, taking big steps. I followed behind him, running. It turned out to be a garter snake, about eight inches long and disappointingly harmless. He let go with a big sigh like he was relieved that I was safe and sound. Then he got mad.

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"I've got a lot of planting to do today. I can't be coming back in unless it's more trouble than that!" He turned toward the house, walking past me, muttering. That was the last he said about the incident and I never rang the bell again.

The following year, on the first of March, we auctioned the farming business and moved to town. Dad said it was because of the price of milk and the recession. I think the work was getting too hard for him.

He got a job working in a milk machine factory in town. It must have been hard on him working inside after all those years of farming, but he never said too much about it. The second spring in town, he was laid off from the factory and was hired to work on a Lipizzan horse farm. This was a blessing because he loved horses.

One day while I was at school, he was leading a big stallion across a hayfield to a new barn when the big horse bolted. The stud horse threw its head, jerking on the leather lead that Dad was holding. I remember him

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saying, "If I would have let go, I would have been all right." Instead he'd held on and fought the horse. Maybe he'd remembered his younger days, cowboying those raw, young draft horses that he had trained to behave and work at a farmer's side. But Dad was old now, and the strain was too much. He had a heart attack and died a short time later. I was sixteen.

In the years that followed, there were times in my life when there was trouble, and I ached to pull on the rope, but I didn't have a bell to ring and he didn't have a tractor to drive in from the field.

This story has been silent for years, like the old bell. But now when I tell it, it feels to me like I'm pulling on the rope. And if you hear that bell, or maybe a bell of your own, then I know I've rung it. Shorty May taught me to listen to the land and to its people, and sometimes while searching my memories, I can hear the tractor coming, too.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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